

MEGATREND FIELD NOTE

# Capital rotates back into strategic capacity

Rising · Evidence current to 27 August 2026

## Executive thesis

Capital is rotating toward assets that create strategic capacity: power, compute, data centers, networks, payment rails, infrastructure and integration capability. This differs from a broad return of risk appetite. Investors are increasingly paying for control over bottlenecks and future options, while demanding clearer utilization and operating plans. The advantage moves from the highest bidder to the owner-operator that can transform an asset, secure scarce inputs and convert capacity into contracted demand.

## The numbers that anchor the view

|                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>\$206 billion</b><br>capital committed to infrastructure funds in 2025, described in the archive as a record year. <sup>[1]</sup> | <b>\$3.4 trillion</b><br>IEA forecast for global energy investment in 2026, 5% above 2025. <sup>[2]</sup>            |
| <b>\$320 billion</b><br>stablecoin market capitalization at end-May 2026, according to the BIS. <sup>[3]</sup>                       | <b>5%</b><br>forecast increase in global energy investment in 2026 versus 2025, according to the IEA. <sup>[2]</sup> |

## How the signal evolved, 2023-2026

### 2023-24 · Capital discipline dominates

Higher uncertainty and financing cost make strategic fit and operating value more important. M&A discussions emphasize discipline, integration and the risk of buying scale without a transformation thesis. <sup>[4][5]</sup>

### 2025 · Infrastructure regains strategic weight

Fundraising and corporate agendas shift toward infrastructure, energy and productive capacity. The attraction is not only yield; it is exposure to digitalization, electrification and constrained systems. <sup>[1][2]</sup>

### 2026 · Utilization and integration define returns

AI capacity, digital assets and larger transactions expand, but the evidence increasingly tests cash conversion, interoperability, residual value and post-deal execution. Capital availability is no longer the differentiator by itself. <sup>[6][7][8]</sup>

# How the trend creates - or destroys - value

## Bottlenecks create option value

Power, connections, data, compute and regulated access can constrain multiple growth markets at once. Ownership or contractual access gives the company strategic freedom beyond the asset's current cash flow. <sup>[2][8]</sup>

## Utilization converts capacity into return

A scarce asset can still destroy value if demand, power or workflow adoption arrives late. Contract structure, customer concentration and refresh cycles therefore matter as much as headline capacity. <sup>[9][10]</sup>

## Active ownership captures the spread

Integration, pricing, operational improvement, AI and talent decisions create the gap between the purchased return and the realized return. The asset must enter an operating playbook before the transaction closes. <sup>[11][7]</sup>

# Economic logic

Strategic-capacity investments should be underwritten through two linked cases. The base case values contracted or observable cash flow under realistic utilization, financing and operating assumptions. The option case values the strategic flexibility created by scarce access, but only when management can define the decisions that access enables. Mixing the two produces inflated returns. For acquisitions, the value-creation plan should also distinguish market growth, synergy, transformation and financing effects. Each requires different evidence and ownership. <sup>[1][11][12]</sup>

# Implications by stakeholder

|                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Investment thesis</b><br><br>Define the bottleneck or strategic option the asset secures and separate that value from the base cash-flow case.  | <b>Diligence</b><br><br>Stress-test utilization, power, customer concentration, financing, interoperability and residual value rather than extrapolating headline demand. |
| <b>Ownership</b><br><br>Build the integration and operating plan before signing, with named owners for pricing, technology, talent and resilience. |                                                                                                                                                                           |

## CEO action agenda

|                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>NEXT 90 DAYS</b></p> <p><b>Map strategic bottlenecks</b></p> <p>Identify where growth depends on scarce power, compute, data, network access, integration skill or regulatory permission.</p> | <p><b>NEXT 90 DAYS</b></p> <p><b>Separate base and option value</b></p> <p>Re-underwrite priority investments with explicit downside utilization and financing cases.</p>                          |
| <p><b>6-12 MONTHS</b></p> <p><b>Pre-build operating playbooks</b></p> <p>Define the first 100-day and two-year value levers before committing capital.</p>                                          | <p><b>6-12 MONTHS</b></p> <p><b>Secure flexible access</b></p> <p>Use partnerships, contracts and modular commitments where ownership would create excessive concentration or technology risk.</p> |

## What could break the thesis

- Capacity scarcity can reverse quickly if technology efficiency improves or demand is delayed.
- Strategic language can conceal weak base economics and encourage overpayment.
- Concentrated exposure to power, semiconductors or regulation can correlate supposedly diversified investments.

## Indicators to monitor

|                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|
| • Contracted versus speculative utilization            |
| • Return split between base cash flow and option value |
| • Power and connection readiness                       |
| • Integration milestones before close                  |
| • Exposure to common bottlenecks                       |

## Evidence boundary and confidence

Medium-high on the rotation toward strategic capacity; medium on asset-level return durability

Rising investment does not prove attractive returns. Utilization, financing cost, integration and regulatory constraints determine whether capacity creates value.

# Sources and traceability

[1] Weekly Brief · 2026-03-24 · Infrastructure Investing Is Back

[2] Authoritative research · IEA · 2026-05-28 · World Energy Investment 2026 · p. 6

[3] Authoritative research · BIS · 2026-06-29 · Anchoring Trust in Money: Innovation Beyond Stablecoins · p. 12

[4] Weekly Brief · 2025-02-11 · Financial Discipline Is Never out of Fashion

[5] Weekly Brief · 2023-10-31 · Is M&A About to Bounce Back?

[6] Weekly Brief · 2026-08-04 · Getting Real About Digital Assets

[7] Weekly Brief · 2026-05-27 · How AI Changes Post-Merger Integration—and Beyond

[8] Authoritative research · Goldman Sachs Global Institute · 2026-05-01 · Tracking Trillions: The Assumptions Shaping the Scale of the AI Build-Out

[9] Authoritative research · Goldman Sachs Research · 2025-12-18 · Why AI Companies May Invest More than \$500 Billion in 2026

[10] Weekly Brief · 2026-07-28 · The AI Bill Lands on the CEO’s Desk

[11] Weekly Brief · 2024-12-04 · Three Myths and One Truth About M&A

[12] Authoritative research · J.P. Morgan Global Research · 2026-07-01 · Mid-Year Market Outlook 2026: The Tug of War Continues

[13] Authoritative research · IMF · 2026-07-08 · World Economic Outlook Update: Global Economy in Crosscurrents of War and Technology

[14] Authoritative research · BCG · 2026-05-18 · The Future of Digital Assets

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